My toe was continuing to pose problems and mentally I was frustrated. It was then that a foot specialist suggested to me that I should have an operation on both my sesamoid bones. In my frustration, I almost agreed and was ready to be on crutches for the next four months, but Anjali dissuaded me from doing so, and in fact spoke to Prof. Cathy Speed in London, who advised that I should avoid surgery. Anjali then came all the way to Australia for just two days to spend some time with me because she was worried that I would go ahead with the surgery out of frustration. I am glad I listened to her and that good sense prevailed.

After the Test series there was widespread speculation that I had made myself available for the subsequent limited-overs tri-series against Sri Lanka and Australia just so that I could score my 100th century. Such statements were frustrating because they were simply untrue. One of the main reasons I played in the series was that MS Dhoni came and said to me, '*Aap rukh jao. Aap rahoge to achha hoga. Aap agar sab match na bhi khelte ho phir bhi aap rukh jao*.' (Please stay. It will be good if you stay. Even if you don't play all the games, please stay.) Perhaps it's difficult for some to understand the obsessive urge to do well for India, but this is what has given my sporting life a purpose.

Despite playing well in patches, however, we didn't make it to the final of the tri-series. There seemed to be a cloud of negativity surrounding the game and fans were starting to lose faith in the team. We needed to get things moving again and the next opportunity to do so was in the Asia Cup in Bangladesh in March 2012.

Try, try, try again …

I scored only six in our first Asia Cup game, a 50-run victory against Sri Lanka in Dhaka on 13 March 2012, and the 'Sachin fails again' cry started up immediately. Fortunately I was not particularly aware of it at the time, though, as my family and friends did their best to shield me from what appeared in the press.

Our next match was against Bangladesh on 16 March on a track that was slightly slower than the one used against Sri Lanka. The ball did not always come on to the bat and it was going to be important to pace the innings and set a big score for the hosts to chase down. Virat and I rotated the strike well and the scoring rate hovered just above the five-